BALLET ▼

FROM RUSSIA WITH LOVE

EIFMAN BALLET FROM ST PETERSBURG BRINGS *ANNA KARENINA*—TOLSTOY'S STORMY PSYCHOLOGICAL DRAMA—TO THE NCPA ON ITS FIRST-EVER INDIA TOUR

Talk of Russian ballet and familiar classics like *Swan Lake*, *Sleeping Beauty*, *Giselle*, *The Nutcracker* come to mind instantly. So, it comes as a surprise that a 50-year-old Russian ballet company in its maiden tour of India will be staging Leo Tolstoy's *Anna Karenina* at the National Centre for Performing Arts [NCPA] in Mumbai from December 8-10. But that's Eifman Ballet, a St Petersburg-based repertory which prides itself for practising a distinct artistic expression that it describes as "Russian psychological ballet theatre". "My productions are distinguished by a meticulously crafted dramaturgical foundation, profound intellectual content and psychological depth," says Boris Eifman, choreographer and artistic director. "But most importantly, everyone who comes to our performances will experience an inner upheaval, a catharsis... our art never leaves anyone indifferent."

And what better than Tolstoy's epic saga about a married woman hopelessly in love with another man and society's judgement of her, to evoke these emotions. In Tolstoy's tragic portrait of Anna and Tchaikovsky's music, Eifman found all the inspiration he needed. "For me, Tolstoy is the true founder of psychoanalysis or, at the very least, its first practitioner in history," says Eifman. "Through dance, I wanted to uncover the hidden layers of this psychological drama—not to retell the novel, but to reveal the inner storms that words cannot express...to discover new layers of meaning that only the language of dance can convey."

For the NCPA, hosting the Eifman Ballet offers a rare opportunity to have a classic western performing art form grace the Jamshed Bhabha Theatre [JBT] stage, which is best known for recitals by the Symphony Orchestra of India whose repertoire includes works by Russian composers. "I had hoped to bring a full-scale Russian ballet to JBT, but the challenge has been our stage, which isn't wide enough to host large ensemble choreographies that many international companies require," says NCPA chairman Khushroo N. Suntook. "Even so, this ballet is exceptionally accomplished, and I believe they will adapt beautifully to our comparatively limited stage." Regardless of space, Tolstoy's tale alone should keep audiences on their toes. ■

—Suhani Singh

Anna Karenina will be performed at NCPA, Mumbai, from Dec. 8-10



ROBERT WORKMAN

Boris Eifman, artistic director of the Eifman Ballet Company, found inspiration in Tolstoy's Anna and Tchaikovsky's music



Just as they have for the past eight years, the ghats of Varanasi will once more ring with the verses of Kabir. The Mahindra Kabira Festival 2025, instituted by the Mahindra Group and produced by Teamwork Arts, is celebrating its ninth edition, bringing together a collective of musicians, thinkers, and cultural voices whose work reflects the 15th-century mystic's legacy of truth, inclusivity and self-inquiry.

From reflections on Kabir's philosophy to engaging discourses, the festival offers a celebration of the mystic poet and saint. Mornings and evenings will come alive with the sounds of music,